

About This Publication

"Tobacco and Health" is published by the Tobacco Information Committee.

While charges against tobacco are widely publicized, the existence of conflicting opinion does not always receive comparable public attention. This issue of "Tobacco and Health" presents a selection of materials indicating that there is more than one side to existing scientific opinion on the possible effects of tobacco use on health.

"Tobacco and Health" will continue to report selected material from a variety of sources, including lay and scientific publications.

The Tobacco Information Committee represents the tobacco manufacturers, growers and warehousemen who support the Tobacco Industry Research Committee. However, the opinions quoted herein are those of the identified sources and do not necessarily represent the official policy or position of members of the Scientific Advisory Board to the Tobacco Industry Research Committee or any recipients of TIRC research grants.

Smoking-Lung Cancer Link Disputed by Six Experts

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which show other factors that may be importantly related to this disease, he said.

He said "discrepancies and fallacies in the cigarette theory are shown, even from those studies often cited in the attempt to incriminate cigarettes."

Dr. R. H. Rigdon, professor of pathology at the University of Texas Medical Branch, Galveston, said the data on which lung cancer is causatively associated with cigarettes are not accurate enough "to permit the conclusions which have been drawn."

Dr. Joseph Berkson, head of the Section of Biometry and Medical Statistics of the Mayo Clinic, wrote the Subcommittee chairman that "I find no reason to modify my previous opinion that the evidence, taken as a whole, does not establish, on any reasonable scientific basis, that cigarette smoking causes lung cancer."

Editors View Smoking-Cancer Tie As Unproved, Open Question

Excerpts From Editorials

From the New York World-Telegram and Sun

Do we have an opinion in this cigaret-lung cancer controversy? We do. We offer it as no more than our opinion but, briefly, it is this:

A relationship obviously has been drawn between excessive cigaret smoking and incidence of lung cancer. But we have yet to hear anyone offer evidence that moderate cigaret smoking, per se, is a cause of lung cancer.

We can't resist the feeling that other areas cry out for exploration. We would like more and deeper research, for example, into whether the irritants and poisonous fumes in polluted air may be an important contributing factor in lung cancer.

Frankly, we're bewildered and we feel the public is, too, by the vast number of claims and counterclaims. For our part, we want to hear a lot more on the entire subject before we'll be convinced one way or another.

But when we say more, we don't mean an interminable rehash of points already on the record. Those can be argued indefinitely and inconclusively. What we're interested in is new evidence.

From the Sacramento (Cal.) Union

The causative chain between smoking and cancer is purely statistical. The causes of cancer and coronary disease are for the most part unknown. Cigaret smoking might conceivably be the outward behavior manifestation of certain types of individuals who, by constitution, might be more predisposed toward coraries or cancer. The smoking and the disease would then be only two elements in a constitutional constellation.

The fact that pipe smoking is relatively harmless, and cigar smoking less so than cigaret smoking indicates that there may be a factor other than tobacco present as a precipitator.

ette smoking causes lung cancer."

"On the contrary, I have found more and stronger reasons to doubt this conclusion," wrote Dr. Berkson, who two years ago published an analysis of the American Cancer Society's statistical study in which he took issue with the report.

Dr. Milton B. Rosenblatt, New York chest specialist and co-author of a recent book on lung cancer, wrote the United States Surgeon General:

"In an issue which seriously involves the public's welfare and which is so highly controversial, the official promotion of one point of view denies the public the opportunity to evaluate the data which reject the proposition that a causal relationship between smoking and lung cancer has been established."

Dr. Rosenblatt then listed eleven facts dealing with lung cancer, and concluded:

"Until the etiology of lung cancer has been firmly established more will be gained by a circumspect point of view. Medicine has had its share of colossal blunders in the past. Not too long ago, tuberculosis was attributed to night air and lung cancer, to tuberculosis."

From the Washington (D. C.) Evening Star

Dr. Burney and the PHS, however, have given voice to some important qualifications. One of these is that more biological and clinical research, as well as more statistical study, is needed to establish a definitive case against cigarette smoking in relation to lung cancer. Another is that there is no "convincing" evidence as yet that heavy use of tobacco is a "causative factor" in heart disease. And a third is that air pollution (urban smog and the like) is a highly suspect thing that calls for intensive investigation to determine how big and villainous a role it may be playing in this matter.

In effect, these qualifications concede that the whole subject still entails such a measure of uncertainty and speculation that the time is not yet here for a final judgment. The Tobacco Industry Research Committee, for example, has cogently challenged the validity of the anti-smoking statistical conclusions. And numerous independent authorities — distinguished doctors in no way associated with the business of selling

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